PRAYER SERIES AT TIFERET EYAL

Blessing the Blessed: The Surprising Origins of Our Morning Prayers

Prayer Series, Part 2

Series: Prayer Series (Tiferet Eyal, 2021-22) **Shiur:** Part 2 of the six-part Prayer Series, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom for Tiferet Eyal, Tuesday 7 December 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap and Plan

Last time the Rabbi covered the origins of prayer as a whole, how prayer works if Hashem already knows our needs, women's obligation in prayer, and a general overview of what tefillah is. Tonight's task was large: to go from **the very beginning of the morning prayers**, the brachot on waking, **all the way to Nishmat on Shabbat**. The aim was to understand the sources of each part, the reasons we say them, and their **relative importance**.

"You think certain things are so ingrained, but actually you start to uncover their origins, and you start to recognise how some things are more important than others."

Part 1: Modeh Ani, a 350-Year-Old Newcomer

Open almost any prayer book and the first thing you find is **מודה אני**. When was it composed? Two thousand years ago? Three thousand?

The first record we have of Modeh Ani is from **the middle of the seventeenth century**, about 350 years ago. In the old **Spanish and Portuguese siddurim** you will not find it at all. **Hacham Gaguine**, in the **Keter Shem Tov**, where he records the Spanish and Portuguese customs, writes that he looked through all the old siddurim and did not find it.

The reason it was instituted: Modeh Ani has **no mention of Hashem's name**, so it may be said as soon as you wake up, before washing your hands. "It's a lovely prayer, don't get me wrong," but it shows how something everyone now takes for granted can be quite late.

Part 2: The Talmudic Morning Blessings

Netilat Yadayim: why do we wash?

Washing hands with a bracha in the morning is a **Talmudic institution**. But the Rishonim argue about the reason:

View	Reason for washing
The Rambam	During the night your hands touched parts of your body, and it is not appropriate to come before Hashem in prayer like that. "It's got nothing to do with evil spirits."
The Rashba, quoting the **Zohar** and kabbalistic sources	A **רוח רעה**, an impure spirit, rests on the hands during sleep

The Shulchan Aruch rules that we should be concerned about the *ruach ra'ah*. This is why people are careful not to walk out of the house before washing.

Hacham Ovadia Yosef held that the whole house counts as **one domain**. As long as you don't leave the house, you may walk to the sink to wash. Some people keep a basin by their bed and won't take a step before washing: "that's a lovely thing, but halachically it's not required."

Asher Yatzar and Elokai Neshama

אשר יצר is a Talmudic blessing, said whenever one goes to the toilet, typically in the morning.

אלהי נשמה שנתת בי has its source in the Talmud, **Berachot 60**. We thank Hashem for creating our soul and returning it to us.

The Rabbi pointed out that **Modeh Ani is a synopsis of Elokai Neshama**. Both thank Hashem for returning the soul. But Elokai Neshama contains Hashem's name and cannot be said before washing. "Whoever instituted Modeh Ani 350 years ago wanted you to begin straight away with the concept of Elokai Neshama as soon as you wake up."

Birkot HaShachar

Then come the morning blessings: **פוקח עורים** (opens the eyes of the blind), **מתיר אסורים** (releases the bound), **זוקף כפופים** (raises the bowed), **מלביש ערומים** (clothes the naked). We thank Hashem for our most basic gifts: to see, move, walk, stand straight, and have strength for the day. All of these are in the Talmud. (The blessing about being made a woman "is a discussion in its own right," for another time.)

Hanoten Laya'ef Koach: one blessing less

One blessing, **הנותן ליעף כח**, "who gives strength to the weary," is in every siddur in the world except one. It is **not in the Talmud** and **not in the Spanish and Portuguese siddur**.

The Rabbi put **Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 46** on the screen. The code of Jewish law for Sephardim says "black and white" that we do **not** say this bracha, because it has no Talmudic source. So how did it spread? As Adrian guessed, through **the Arizal**, who held it was a correct blessing to make. It then spread across all the Middle Eastern Sephardim and is in every Middle Eastern siddur. The Spanish and Portuguese, however, still do not say it, "because the Shulchan Aruch says not to do it, and the Spanish and Portuguese never follow Kabbalah." They say one blessing fewer each morning.

She'asa Li Kol Tzorki on Yom Kippur and Tisha B'Av

Jillian asked about communities that omit **שעשה לי כל צרכי** on a fast day. It is a halachic debate, the Rabbi said, and it concerns only **Yom Kippur and Tisha B'Av**, not other fasts. The blessing thanks Hashem for our basic need to walk and go out, which needs shoes. Since shoes are forbidden on those days, some omit it. **Hacham Ovadia held that one does say it.** The blessing itself is Talmudic either way.

Birkot HaTorah

The blessings over the Torah are clearly in the Talmud, in Berachot. The Rabbi cited the famous Gemara in **Nedarim**: the Beit HaMikdash was destroyed because **לא ברכו בתורה תחילה**, on the simple meaning, they did not say the blessings over the Torah. Learning Torah is not just an academic, intellectual pursuit. It is recognising that Hashem gave us a way to connect with and understand "the mind of the Creator of the universe."

The Gemara's text asks **והערב נא**, "make it sweet for us." The Rabbi compared it to the saying: if you get a job you enjoy, you'll never have to work a day in your life. We ask that Torah be sweet in our mouths, so that it never feels like work.

The order of importance

After the Amidah and the Shema, the next most important part of Shacharit is Birkot HaShachar and Birkot HaTorah.

These first two or three pages are Talmudically obligated. Everything after them, even Baruch She'amar, is not from the Talmud. "Unfortunately, you see sometimes people come late and they just join in the middle. But it's not correct." If you come late, begin with these. And there is no point saying the whole prayer book while rushing the brachot of the morning.

Part 3: What Does It Mean to Bless Hashem?

Every blessing begins **ברוך אתה ה׳ אלהינו מלך העולם**. But how can we bless Hashem? He doesn't need our blessing.

As always, the Rabbi said, look to the root. **ב־ר־ך** has two meanings in Tanach:

ברך, **a knee**: bending the knee, prostrating, acknowledging *berech*.

ברכה, *berechah*, **a pool** or spring of water. That's why a swimming pool in modern Hebrew is a *brecha*: a collection of water.

So when we say *Baruch Atah Hashem* we are not blessing Hashem. We are acknowledging that **He is the source**, the spring from which everything flows. Every time we benefit from something in this world, we acknowledge Him as the source of it all.

The Maharal: just beyond one

The **Maharal of Prague** noted that the letters of **ברך** are each "just above one":

Letter	Value
ב	2
ר	200
כ	20

The idea of a bracha is that by recognising Hashem as the source of everything, **we bring down more *shefa***, more energy and divine flow. Once you recognise the oneness of Hashem, the One, that brings down further abundance, "just beyond the one."

Part 4: Korbanot

After Birkot HaShachar come the Korbanot, opening with the **Akedah**. The Rabbi asked: if you had only thirty seconds to say **one paragraph** between the Akedah and the Kaddish after Rabbi Yishmael, which would it be?

Someone suggested the **Ketoret**: "That I would say is second most important." The answer is **פרשת התמיד**, the daily offering: **צו את בני ישראל ואמרת אלהם את קרבני לחמי לאשי**.

- **Why?** The whole of Tefillat HaShachar corresponds to the **morning Tamid**. That is the reason we pray Shacharit at all.
- The Rabbi showed the **Shulchan Aruch**: after Birkot HaShachar and Birkot HaTorah, the only thing in this section he writes you must say is the **Korban HaTamid**. The rest is "good to say."
- Saying the Tamid goes back to the **Geonim**, about 1,300 or 1,400 years, already in the **siddur of Rav Amram Gaon**.
- The **Akedah** and other passages are much later. The **Tur** in the fourteenth century records them as custom, which is why the Shulchan Aruch only says it is good to say them.
- **Kabbalah** places great importance on saying **Shema Yisrael** here too; according to the kabbalists one should say the Shema four times a day (twice in Shacharit, once in Arvit, once before sleep). That too is much later. Of course the verses of the Akedah are from the Torah, but saying them daily is a far later recommendation than the Tamid.

Eizehu Mekoman and Rabbi Yishmael

The **Gemara in Kiddushin** says a person should learn every day **a bit of Chumash, a bit of Mishnah and a bit of Gemara**. So we say:

Requirement	Fulfilled by
Chumash	The Korban HaTamid
Mishnah	**איזהו מקומן**, the chapter on the places of the sacrifices
Gemara (Talmudic-style literature)	**רבי ישמעאל אומר**, the thirteen principles of Torah interpretation

Why choose *Eizehu Mekoman* from all the Mishnayot? On a simple level, because prayer replaces the sacrifices. But many chapters deal with sacrifices.

"Let me tell you something remarkable about Eizehu Mekoman. The chapter of Eizehu Mekoman, believe this or not, is the only chapter in the entire Mishnah which hasn't got an argument between the Rabbis."

There is no "Rabbi Meir says this, Rabbi Yehudah says that." No names at all, only halachot. As **Hacham Gaguine** brings in the **Keter Shem Tov**, we want to begin the day **without machloket**.

Kaddish

After the Korbanot we say **Kaddish Al Yisrael**. The principle: after **rabbinic statements**, Kaddish Al Yisrael; after **verses**, Kaddish Yehe Shelama.

Part 5: Pesukei DeZimrah

Everyone else calls this section Pesukei DeZimrah. Uniquely, among the Spanish and Portuguese the whole service up to this point is called **Zemirot**. But where does the practice of saying Baruch She'amar, Yishtabach and all the Hallelukahs in between come from?

Not an obligation in the Talmud

Two Gemarot indicate that it was **not** required daily practice:

1. **Shabbat 118b:** Rabbi Yossi says, **יהא חלקי מגומרי הלל בכל יום**, "May my portion be with those who complete Hallel every day." This doesn't mean the Hallel of Hanukkah, as is clear from context. It means reciting praise of Hashem. In the time of the Tannaim it was considered a fortunate thing to say these psalms daily, but not a requirement.
2. **Berachot 4b:** whoever says **Ashrei** three times a day is **guaranteed a portion in the World to Come**. "You don't give these guarantees to things which are obligatory."

On Ashrei the Rabbi added: "Nothing in Judaism works by recitals." Ashrei runs from aleph to tav. Saying it three times a day means living the whole day with the recognition, from A to Z, that Hashem is the source of everything. Someone who lives intimately with Hashem like that of course has a portion in the World to Come.

In the time of the **Geonim** these Zemirot were the praiseworthy thing to say. By the **Rishonim**, about a thousand years ago, they had basically become obligatory. (Asked about **Hodu**, the Rabbi said where to place it is a later debate; Ashkenazim say it after Baruch She'amar, and it is really part of Pesukei DeZimrah.)

Why praise comes first

Pesukei DeZimrah opens with a bracha, **Baruch She'amar**, and closes with one, **Yishtabach**, with praises in between. As we learned last time, every prayer should begin with **shevach**, praise, before asking. The Amidah itself opens with three blessings of praise before the first request, for wisdom. Modelled on that, a whole section of praise precedes the prayer.

Who wrote Baruch She'amar?

- **The prevalent view among the later Rishonim:** composed by one of the **Geonim** of the seventh or eighth century. The first text we have of it is from the **ninth century**.
- **Another view:** it goes back to the **Men of the Great Assembly**, about 2,300 years ago, written when a paper with the text fell from heaven.

Robert asked how the Geonim could compose a bracha. "An excellent question... something I need to think about." If it is from the Men of the Great Assembly there is no question. If it is Geonic, it is harder, but not strange: the Ashkenazi Rishonim composed many brachot for Yom Tov, as in the *yotzrot*.

The long text and the 87 words

In the original manuscripts **Baruch She'amar is a very long text**, and to the Rabbi's knowledge **the only community that preserves it today is the Spanish and Portuguese**. All other siddurim, Ashkenazi and Middle Eastern Sephardi, have a much shorter version of **87 words**, because **the Arizal** held that kabbalistically it must contain 87 words, so it was cut down.

The Rabbi pointed to the Middle Eastern siddurim, which on Shabbat print a passage in brackets **before** Baruch She'amar about Hashem giving Shabbat to Israel. That passage comes from the long Spanish

and Portuguese text. Because it was so beautiful, someone placed it before the blessing, so that at least it would still be said.

"It just shows how much change we've had in the last 500 years based on the Arizal, and how the Spanish and Portuguese resisted all of these changes and kept to the original text, like we've seen with Birkot HaShachar, like we've seen now with Baruch She'amar."

Holding the tzitzit

During Baruch She'amar we hold the tzitzit together. The Rabbi was not sure of the origin of the minhag, but it is recorded as old in the **Keter Shem Tov**, and Hacham Gaguine explains it:

- Each corner has **8 strings and 5 knots = 13**.
- Two corners held together: **26**, the numerical value of Hashem's name.
- The word **Baruch** appears **13 times** in Baruch She'amar, but Hashem's name only once. Holding the tzitzit, it is as if we say Hashem's name with them.

What comes first if you are short of time?

Within Pesukei DeZimrah there is Ashrei, which is very important, and the Shirah. ("I'm not going to go through each of the Hallelukahs. That would be a whole series of shiurim.") But if the choice is between Birkot HaShachar and Baruch She'amar/Yishtabach, there is no question: **Birkot HaShachar**, because they are from the Talmud.

Pesukei DeZimrah or the Amidah with the minyan? If you come late, do you join the tzibur for the Amidah, or start from Baruch She'amar and miss the minyan? A thousand years ago, when Pesukei DeZimrah was just becoming established, the Amidah and Shema with the minyan clearly trumped it. But the later you go in the halachic responsa, the more ingrained Pesukei DeZimrah became, and the more the position was articulated that it is better to pray alone than to miss Pesukei DeZimrah. "Of course we should say it every day. I'm not in any way coming to say that shouldn't be the case. What I'm saying is that you need to always recognise the source and origin of things, so you know their relevance, their importance relative to one another."

Pesukei DeZimrah after the Amidah?

Irene asked about saying the skipped Pesukei DeZimrah afterwards. "I'm sorry to say, it's a bit ridiculous." Its whole purpose is to begin with praise:

"It's like you're about to play a football game. You go for stretches before. Pesukei DeZimrah are the stretching before the prayer. It's like you play the football game and then you go for your stretches afterwards."

It is always good to stretch, and reading psalms is wonderful, but once you have prayed the Amidah, Pesukei DeZimrah is over.

Part 6: Shabbat and Nishmat

The paradox of the Shabbat prayers

On a weekday the Amidah has **19 blessings**; on Shabbat only **7**. The Talmud says that on Shabbat the rabbis did not want to burden us (*tircha*) with a long prayer. Shabbat is not a time to start worrying about parnasah, health and wisdom.

The paradox is that the Shabbat service is the longest of the week. But look at what was removed and what was added. The Hachamim removed **requests**, which put us under stress: "I need this, God, give me that." What was added is **praise, connection, intimacy with Hashem**: the extra *mizmorim* of Shabbat, and among them **Nishmat**, which concludes Pesukei DeZimrah.

The meaning of Nishmat

Nishmat is "a beautiful, beautiful prayer, one of the most beautiful parts of our service," and very emotional. It is a statement of **the gap between mortal human beings and the Divine**: "we're simply not on the same playing field." We cannot grasp the extent of Hashem's kindness, the multitude of miracles and wonders He does for us at every moment. The Rabbi urged everyone to read it in English and understand what they are saying.

Who wrote Nishmat?

It is mentioned in the **Gemara**, so it is certainly very old. But its authorship is "absolutely remarkable."

1. Yitzchak and Rivka. The Rabbi showed the text on screen: the first letters of four stanzas spell **יצחק**, and there is also **רבקה**. Some suggest an otherwise unknown author named Yitzchak, with Rivka, composed it with this acrostic. This is a common position in the Rishonim.

2. Rabbeinu Tam: Shimon Kefa, Saint Peter. Rabbeinu Tam, Rashi's grandson in the twelfth century, "the greatest Ashkenazi Rishon," held that the author was **Shimon Kefa**, known as **Saint Peter**, based on the acrostic **שמעון** found in Ashkenazi siddurim.

The Rabbi told the background. Peter lived in the first century and was one of Jesus' first disciples. The early Christians faced a question: did converts to Christianity also need to convert to Judaism, and keep how much? Some said full conversion; Paul said no circumcision and no dietary laws; Peter held they must keep the seven Noahide laws. A legend recorded in the eleventh or twelfth century (whether it is true "you have to ask historians") says Peter was a **secret observant Jew**, sent by the Hachamim to infiltrate the early church. The rabbis feared early Christianity resembled Judaism too much and would draw Jews towards it. His mission was to rise to influence and give Christianity its own identity: according to the legend, he moved the day of rest from Saturday to Sunday and instituted different festivals. To keep his secret connection with Judaism he composed Nishmat, and the Hachamim gave it a prominent place in recognition of his work.

3. The objection. The **Machzor Vitry**, also twelfth century, rejects this sharply: "There are those who say concerning Peter that he established this prayer. God forbid, no such thing should occur in Israel. Anyone who says this, when the Temple is built, will have to bring a sin offering."

There is also an opinion attributing it to **Shimon ben Shetach**. "It's just fascinating" that a Rishon as great as Rabbeinu Tam suggested Nishmat was written by one of the early Christian saints.

"Either way it's definitely a holy prayer, whichever opinion you hold... It's said in special times, and we should always make sure to try to say it with as much kavanah as possible."

Summary

1. **Modeh Ani** is a mid-seventeenth-century addition, absent from the old Spanish and Portuguese siddurim. It is a synopsis of **Elokai Neshama** (Berachot 60) without Hashem's name, so it can be said before washing.
2. **Netilat Yadayim:** the Rambam (hygiene and dignity) vs the Rashba/Zohar (*ruach ra'ah*). The Shulchan Aruch takes the *ruach ra'ah* into account; Hacham Ovadia allows walking to the sink within the house.

3. **Birkot HaShachar** are Talmudic, except **Hanoten Laya'ef Koach**, which the Shulchan Aruch (OC 46) says not to say. It spread through the Arizal; the Spanish and Portuguese still omit it.
4. **Order of importance:** Amidah and Shema, then Birkot HaShachar and Birkot HaTorah. Latecomers should not skip them.
5. **Bracha** means acknowledging Hashem as the **source** (knee, pool); the Maharal's "just beyond one" brings down *shefa*.
6. **Korbanot:** the **Tamid** is the essential paragraph (Shulchan Aruch); **Eizehu Mekoman** is the one Mishnah chapter with no dispute (Keter Shem Tov); Chumash, Mishnah and Gemara daily (Kiddushin).
7. **Pesukei DeZimrah** was not obligatory in the Talmud (Shabbat 118b; Berachot 4b), was praiseworthy for the Geonim and effectively obligatory by the Rishonim. Praise comes before requests, like stretching before a game.
8. **Baruch She'amar:** Geonic (first text ninth century) or from the Men of the Great Assembly. The long original text survives only among the Spanish and Portuguese; others cut it to 87 words following the Arizal.
9. **Shabbat** removes requests and adds praise. **Nishmat** expresses the gap between man and Hashem. Its author: Yitzchak and Rivka, Shimon ben Shetach, or, according to Rabbeinu Tam, Shimon Kefa (Saint Peter), which the Machzor Vitry vehemently rejects.

Coming Up

Next week: the **Shema** and the blessings before and after it. Same time, same Zoom link.

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